Pedagogic reflections on the "*Via Negativa*"

by Giovanni Fusetti, May 2024

The term *Via Negativa* is often associated with Lecoq's pedagogy but he himself never used it to define his work, or at least not to my knowledge. I never heard it while I was at Lecoq's as a student, pedagogic assistant or teacher. This was in the 90s. The first time I heard the term in reference to the pedagogic work was when I was teaching at the *Dell'Arte School of Physical Theater* in the US in 2006. *Dell'Arte School* was founded by Carlo Mazzone-Clementi, one of the early collaborators of Lecoq in Italy between 1948 and 1956. At *Dell'Arte School* they were referring to *Via Negativa* as a style of teaching. So I started exploring the term and eventually I figured out that it actually contains many different aspects and that it is often misused, or used to define something else than what the actual *Via Negativa* is.

Via Negativa: the negative way

The actual term belongs to philosophical tradition. It was originally a theological term that philosophers and theologians created as a way of defining God *by what God is not*[1].

In its larger sense, it is a way of referring to a process or a concept not by defining what that process is, but by what it is not.

In this sense, it was certainly present in some aspects of the pedagogic approach of Lecoq and his school. One of the most common examples, is the way an improvisation class is typically set. The teacher announces the theme (or task), setting the space and the urgencies in it, but they explain very little of what is there to be found. Then the students explore the theme for a certain amount of time, until the teacher stops them and gives feedback. The theme is progressively explored and developed by multiple rounds of improvisations and the gems are found, somehow collectively and eventually what is found becomes the learning.

One benefit of this design is that it provokes the students to search, explore and take risks. The students do not know what they are looking for, they come without preconceived ideas so play can happen more easily. They may even find something new about the theme itself, something that even the teacher did not know was there.

A significant part of Lecoq's program emerged from this approach. It was somehow *found* by the students while the teacher was holding the space for the exploration and the rules of engagement with the work.

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[1] *Apophatic theology*, also known as *negative theology* is a form of theological thinking and religious practice which attempts to approach God, the Divine, by negation, to speak only in terms of what may not be said about the perfect goodness that is God. We find this principle in classical Greek Philosophy, as well as in Christianity, Judaism, Islam as well as in various Indian traditions. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Apophatic_theology

If you don't search you will not find. In synthesis you could summarize this setting in *"here is the theme: search inside it and you will find something very important. I will not tell you what it is until you find it, but I will tell you when you don't make it."*

The skill of the teacher is in the design (or framing) of the theme and in the quality of their feedback.

In a non-theoretical and highly experiential learning process like Lecoq's approach, one crucial task of the teacher is to decide what to say before the exercise and what to say after. The setting and the feedback.

The feedback

The *via negativa* approach to feedback consists of giving feedback on what is not there and what does not work. The teacher withholds saying what does work or what needs to be found and how to find it. The class then unfolds through the attempts of the students, who are trying to find out what there is to be learnt within each particular genre of theatre study.

The basic question for any teacher is: what do you say after the students have presented their offering? A strict *via negativa* style will reduce the feedback to: *C'est ça.* Or its opposite: *C'est pas ça*. This is it. This is not it.

So the students will keep searching, hoping to find what is to be found and thus be successful in the exercise.

Again, the pedagogic value here is that it trains the students to an essential fact: that in order to find you have to search. Sometimes the search is very hard.

The downside is that when a student does find something, if they don't get feedback on what they have found (and how they found it), they may never learn anything from that failure, except frustration, disempowerment or competitiveness. Furthermore, they might never be able to find it again.

Another downside of not giving feedback on what is found is that the student may fall into the pattern of "pleasing the master", instead of finding good theatrical material, learning something and thus finding "the work".

The Poet wants to please the Muses not the teacher.

This is why, in my view, the *via negativa* needs to be applied very carefully, deliberately and with full awareness of its consequences.

The students always find something. Even finding nothing is something. The lack of feedback can become a lack of learning about the learning process itself.

This is where the orthodox Lecoq approach can be ineffective. Often students will find something and receive just a *voila c'est ça* without necessarily understanding what was actually found. The consequence of this is often the inability to recreate and repeat the good material that was found.

The one who doesn't know what they have, has nothing.

In a pedagogic process aiming to train theatre devisers, there are a few fundamental questions that the teacher needs to address when it comes to giving feedback.

What kind of feedback shall I give, if any, when people find something?
What kind of support shall I give to what is found?
How can I support the process of the students to return to this material and assist them to develop it further, in a self-sustainable way?

I have often seen that *via negativa* applied as "no feedback on what is found" doesn't train people to learn how to recognize what they find. Rather it creates a very highly competitive structure and learning field, where *scarcity* is the operating principle.

Setting trials

Part of the teacher's role is to decide the amount of information given, before and after the exercise or activity. The other fundamental set of decisions concerns the structure of the training itself and the setting of the tasks. At times, the teacher deliberately creates obstacles in order to learn how to overcome them and to make the students more fierce in their quest.

I have often heard people associating the "hardness" of the task with the term "*via negativa*". I think this is a misuse of this term.

A teacher can design hard tasks with plenty of feedback or hard tasks with very limited or no feedback. The terms *via negativa* would apply to the latter.

In this case a *via negativa* approach would look like this. As a teacher, you create an obstacle, a trial, a difficult task, you don't say what is there to be found and the students have to find it by themselves. You make it difficult by giving very little traces or no traces whatsoever and very little feedback, like yes or no. The students will work harder until they find it. And often they'll find nothing. So they have to deal with frustration and defeat.

The downside of this is that it creates a highly competitive environment and some students, or many, will give up. There will be a high fatality rate of students who will not reach a state of self-sustaining poetic power.

The worst case scenario is a pedagogic set up where not only the tasks are hard and no feedback nor support is given, but there is no training of the techniques that would allow the student to actually succeed in the task. This inevitably ends up in a power game between the teacher and the students. Students who are struggling to survive and fighting for the scarce food available become surrounded by the high casualties of their colleagues. Those who already have some skills and perhaps an organic predisposition to the work might succeed, but the rest, the struggling ones, will be lost.

The role of support

Another element of the teaching process that is often associated with the term *via negativa* is the absence of support.

The training of any art form can be challenging. In moments it can not **not** be challenging. This is connected with the struggle involved in learning a technique, any technique. With this term I refer to a set of skills, with whom the artist can impact and transform the matter that is the medium of their art. In physical theatre the medium is the body. This involves its physical, mental and emotional dimension. Learning a technique involves rigor, engagement, fun, persistence, frustration, jubilation, practice and more practice, successes and failure, feelings of triumph and of defeat, and much more. When this training happens in a group, this involves a whole set of interpersonal dynamics, from cooperation to competition, from admiration to envy, from a sense of belonging to a sense of isolation and much more. Personal and collective psychological patterns will manifest, past wounds and trauma can be re-activated by the creative process.

When in difficulties, humans have the option of supporting each other or not. This is another fundamental pedagogic dilemma. Any teacher needs to decide what kind of support, if any, will be provided to the students.

There are many ways of provide a supporting learning environment.

One is for the teacher to name and frame the successful events, and encourage the student to remember the successes and process them into awareness.

Then there is the specificity of the feedback, that it is consistent with the learning history of each individual student.

Another option is to include accurate and comprehensible technical training, in order to provide the tools to overcome the difficulties when they appear.

And then there is a whole set of options involving the support of the personal process of the student, which can include at times emotional support.

Support can be present, but not always. The absence of support can be part of the design of some classes within a training program or of some sessions within a specific class.

I have noticed that often the term *via negativa* is used to describe a pedagogic process that does not involve any support. A tough teaching approach that creates very hard obstacles, without giving any emotional support while students are struggling and failing. With a teacher who doesn't support or help or give them feedback on their personal processes or on how to overcome the particular difficulty they are experiencing in the work. A teacher who never addresses any personal aspect of the student process, but only the result of their work.

Lecoq often operated in this mode. This can be a clear setting in which as a student you are aware of the lack of support from the beginning, and you are not expecting any help. If you can make it, it will be thanks to your own resources and self resilience. And if you don't survive, than this work is not your call.

Quoting Lecoq: *people say that I am a tough teacher. The audience will be tougher.*

The virtuous form of the archetypal figure of the tough teacher is the "initiator" or the "master of arms", who will deliberately and ruthlessly mentor students through painful trials, to prepare them for the world "out there" identified as a battlefield, in order to give them more chances to survive and thrive. This can be seen in a mentor who knows when it is important to let the learner face the harshness of the task alone, knows when a moment of direct support is necessary and knows what is the best way to provide it.

The shadow form of this role is the "abusive teacher".

The abusive teacher

The abusive teacher is the role that not only doesn't give support and doesn't give feedback on what needs to be found, or on what the students actually find, but also gives destructive feedback to the student as a person. This is the case when a teacher treats the students in a way that will dismiss them. This creates an atmosphere where not only there is no support, but there is an active dismissing of the student capacity and personality. Often sarcasm is part of this mode. And public shaming.

The teacher makes the student's life miserable, sometimes with the pretext of provoking their bouncing back.

This role might operate following principles like these:

I break them down before they can be restructured.

I push them until they push back against me.

The teacher's role has power and the abuse of power can hurt. When a student feels that the teacher can randomly hurt them, for many students fear will become a permanent state.

The term *abusive* has a clear pejorative tone. A more nuanced term would be the "sadistic teacher". In the language of psychology, sadism is the attitude of finding pleasure in inflicting pain to another person. Which is the case with a teacher who finds visible pleasure in "breaking down" their students, or finds pleasure in being feared by the students.

When it feels like the teacher is enjoying this kind of power game, it is crucial that the student can see this as a red flag to orient their choice of training. Some students can function in this dynamic, or even thrive. Others will be completely shut down by it. I am convinced that in the context of adult education, the student needs to take responsibility of their learning style and needs.

During my pedagogic practice and through many exchanges with students and colleagues, I realized that this is what people often refer to as *via negativa*: a sado-masochistic field in which teachers are abusive towards their own students, who accepts this as an inevitable part of their training - they might even consider it of value.

The term "sado-masochistic" has a clear psycho-pathological tone, but contains two archetypes of any asymmetric power relation: "the master and servant", the

“teacher and apprentice”, “parent and child” are archetypal roles that are at the core of a learning process.

They are manifestations of the polarities of *over* and *under* in the field of human interactions.

They are embedded in the pedagogic process and they contain some precious dynamic of transmission of knowledge and experience.

The “follower” will accept and trust the master, and will ”follow them to hell” recognizing their wisdom and experience and in the desire of learning a particular art or path.

This asymmetric dynamic between teacher and student is not intrinsically good or bad, right or wrong. It has light and shadows. My point is that the teacher needs to be aware of both roles and take careful decisions around them.

Whether as teachers we are teaching a content or a process, a technique or a path, we are required by the role to model leadership.

The role of the Teacher has leadership by definition. The capacity and will to take decisions that will provoke frustration and in times even pain to others, it is an inevitable and necessary ingredient of leadership and mentorship. From parenting to politics, from education to sport training.

So the question is not *if* but *how* to manifest this role.

Again, we need to articulate this aspect of the *via negativa* acknowledging that toughness can be in times a necessary option, but it has to be used with rigor, care and awareness.

This pattern is very present in sports, and even more in the military training, or in the training of any profession that needs to operate in potentially dangerous contexts, like police officers, firemen, rescue teams, security guards. In the army an elder officer will try to make the training of the young soldiers as tough and as hellish as possible, because the war zone will be worse. The heaviness and the harshness of the training, might give the soldiers more chances to survive on the battlefield.

Applied to a theatre training, this mode views the training of actor-creators as the training of warriors, who will be able to self sustain their quest. This mode will actually become a selecting criteria within a class.

Devising theater, devising physical theater, self-producing, self-devising, self-directing, making a free-lance career devising shows… it is a tough path. It requires fierce engagement and a lot of self-resilience. One way to train in this is to give strictly no support.

This mode was present at the Lecoq school, that was structured with strong competition and a strict selection between first and second year, with a rate of one out of three who would make it.

A very clear downside of this mode, is the high number of casualties. Students that may have some great poetic qualities but do not have, yet, the fierceness to make it through the school will just fall out or vanish. Sometimes giving up the artistic path forever.

The same happens to students who would need an initial dose of specific support in order to reach that self-resilience and then take off.

Another consequence of this approach is the creation of the myth of difficulty, harshness and even trauma around the training experience.

The danger of the *via negativa* approach is that it can imply a view of the world as run by scarcity, competition and harshness. Archetypally, it is in the lineage of 'The Romantic Hero' who needs to suffer in order to fullfill the call of feelings.

It also implies a social, anthropological and political view of the world, as a battlefield for the "survival of the fittest". A field of scarcity and competition where support is not available, not asked and not given. Therefore not expected.

A final note on this "sadistic teacher": those who tend to operate from this mode will often overprice their work. And they will have oversized classes, which is another way to reduce the feedback available to each student. This will play well with the masochistic side of their potential students who will pay a lot for inconsistent, poor, scarce or even abusive feedback.

Positive **and** ***Negative*** **Feedback**

I never use these categories. There is quality feedback and there is poor feedback.

The word feedback contains the verb *to feed*. The feedback has to be, by definition, nurturing. A more poetic word would be *foodback*.

A quality feedback is an intentional, comprehensible and receivable set of information related to a phenomenon that a student has just experienced and a teacher and a class have just witnessed. This information is given to the student in order to feed their process and provoke an increase in their awareness of the process itself. It is something that will nurture the student and something they can cook with in their next recipe.

The duality Positive and Negative Feedback is a misleading category and contributes to the great confusion that I have noticed in reference to the *via negativa*.

If we identify the term *negative feedback* with an abusive and dismissing response that will demoralise and hurt the student, without actually addressing the learning process nor the content, then of course we want to avoid that. But I would define that as *poor feedback* or *an abusive feedback*.

But if by *negative feedback* we mean a direct and comprehensible description of what in the work presented by the student doesn't work, then this is a crucial part of the learning. It is extremely helpful and it cannot be eliminated without catastrophic consequences in the quality of the training itself.

Theatrical technique is not an opinion: whether it is the rhythm, the articulation, the vocal delivery, the state or play, the mask take, the staging, the adherence to a particular genre. These are principles that the students are learning and need to be kept at the centre of the feedback process. The teacher nurtures the potential of the students while holding them accountable for their errors. This is where the learning happens.

The teacher has the ethical duty and responsibility to be as clear and as skilled as possible in the definition of the set of techniques that they decide to teach.

Then they can give quality feedback to the errors of the students.

The word *error* comes from Latin verb *errare*, which could be translated as *wandering off the given path.* The student in their quest for a path, wanders off and the teacher will give feedback on where the student has gone. It is like describing a geographical map together. A geo-poetic and a geo-emotional map [2].

If you go this way, you will end up there. This is not where this work wants to go, but remember the track. This might be where you want to go. But not here, not now, not yet.

My use of the *Via Negativa*

When students engage in a training, what they are mainly looking for, is to learn a particular body of techniques and to receive quality feedback on their learning process. And to meet other fellow practitioners to learn with and, potentially, to create work with.

This is what they engage for and this is what they pay the teacher for.

I am a fond practitioner of accurate, abundant and phenomenologically based feedback. Feedback that describes what the students have found or what is there even if it is not what we are actually looking for. This is my most common mode of teaching. Feedback based gardening.

It trains the "patterns recognition" skill in the student, which in my view is part of the core learning for the actor-creator.

This is what I see.
This is what we are looking for.
This is not what we are looking for, it is what you found.
This works or this doesn't work, for these reasons, based on the theatre language that we are studying and these techniques and rules that we are practicing.

When we work with quality feedback, any failure or flop can be an excellent learning moment for everybody in the class, including the teacher. And it can be fun.

One crucial skill for the actor-creator to learn is how to reproduce the work found through improvisation. When students find *great scenes or characters or texts* through improvisation, they find a treasure. Feedback can be like a treasure map. *A lack of feedback often leads to those treasures never being found again.*

I consider a "clean" and framed use of the *via negativa* as a tool that can be used when it is needed because of what it can provide. But only combined with other modes.

So I use it carefully, when I consciously need to allow frustration to be part of the pedagogic process. I create specific classes, or moments within a single class, in which I give very little feedback, or I let people struggle, or even fail. I always combine this with

[2] Jacques Lecoq describes the journey through different theatrical genres as the *vojage geodramatique* (geodramatic journey). Jacques Lecoq: *Le Corps Poetique*, pp. 107.

other classes structured around extensive feedback and repetition or even active specific support. Technical or emotional.

At one point during my early years of pedagogic passion and training, I realized that the role of the *Mentor* is a combination of a *Nurturer* and an *Initiator*. I want and need to be able to shift between these two roles in me, and design training programs in which these roles can be held in specific classes or by specific teachers.

In a garden there is the time for putting tuteurs to plants and a time for pruning them.

For this reason I have trained extensively in a variety of psycho-social disciplines and practices, in order to better understand the emotional dimension underlying the creative theatrical process and the pedagogic process, as well as my role in them. My training in *Gestalt Therapy* and *Process Oriented Psychology*, as well as my long term research in the field of *Somatic Psychology* in the lineage of Wilhelm Reich, gave me the skills and the option to accompany the students in the land of the wounds, when and if that is necessary. So we can come back with poetic treasures and further personal awareness. This background also allows me to notice if the student is in need of further and more specific emotional support, that can be found in a deliberate therapeutic context, outside of the training itself and by reaching out to other professional figures.

The Pedagogue as a Servant

Etymologically, the word *pedagogue* comes the Greek word *paidagōgos*[3], composed by the term *pedo = child*. And *agōgos* = leader. The leader of the child. The *pedagogue* was a slave in the Greek house, whose task was to attend to the education of the children.

I am aware that in the English language this word has a rather pejorative tone, in the sense of a dogmatic and dull type of teacher. But in Italian, my mother language, and in French, the mother language of my theatre training, this word has maintained the status of a master teacher, an artist of transmission, a designer of learning processes.

As pedagogues, we are "at the service " of our students as well as at the service of the Art that we are teaching. Our task is to provide a rigorous and nurturing field for the students to develop into who they need to become. It is an asymmetric role, in which knowledge, skills and experience are transferred, from one generation to the next. This is an archetypal process for the human community, and it manifests eldership, care and power. It is, ultimately, an act of love, with profound aesthetic, social and political consequences. An act of love for the students, for the art that we are teaching and for the world and the society we live in; a deep engagement with the past, the present and the future of an art and with everyone engaged in it.

The *via negativa* approach to theatre training, requires a strict and compassionate awareness of the power dynamic that is embedded in the teaching and learning process. Only then can it be used to serve the ultimate goal of any pedagogic process, which is the unfolding of the students' potential: their artistic, poetic and personal empowerment.

[3] https://www.etymonline.com/word/pedagogue

Pedagogy is the Art of Teaching

Teaching is the Art of giving feedback

The essence of feedback is in recognizing patterns
and bringing them to awareness

The art of describing forms as they manifest

Rigorous, empathic and poetic phenomenology

Forms are Masks
Masks are Forms
Figures emerging from the background

Gestures, characters, rhythms…
exercises, classes, dramatic territories…
they are all patterns of the Poetic Body

Understanding patterns is the essence of devising

The creation of patterns of beauty
is the path of the Artist